

Introduction

A lot of conversation surrounding programming languages is often, unfortunately, mired in declaring one programming language better than the other. There will probably never be just one single programming language to rule them all, and more importantly there shouldn't be. There is need for diverse kinds of programming languages to meet the diverse needs of software. As a professional developer you can never stop after you have mastered one programming language, you need to be as programmable as the computers you deal with.

Fact is, there is no 'best tool', just the best tool for the job. The same can be said of programming languages. Often the best programming language for the job isn't just a factor of the technical merits of a language, but of the nature of the software itself, the goals of the software and even how the software will be developed and deployed.

The perfect example of this is OwnCloud. It's an open source project aimed at giving people control over their own data. The software has apps for cloud storage, calendar, music streaming, photo storage and more. It can also sync local files to the cloud like Dropbox. Best of all you can host it where you want, so you control where your data goes.

The developers of OwnCloud choose PHP for the project despite there being better and easier languages available. They had some very good reasons for their choice of PHP despite its poor reputation. PHP is often supported by even the cheapest of hosting providers, and in the cheapest of packages. This is great given OwnCloud's goals of reaching a wide audience. It's also great at attracting developers, since it is a popular language known by many developers, and easy to learn for others.

Just like the iPhone is a bad app platform if you want to reach Indian farmers, sometimes technical decisions need a non-technical context. For a software aiming for popularity it's important to look at the lowest common denominator; in OwnCloud's case it was PHP. Choosing Ruby or Python or even Node would be antithetical to the goals of the software.

The key is in finding the best language for the job. In some cases it chosen for you – or strongly suggested – as is the case with Java for Android, or